UNDERSTANDING DIGITAL PRIVACY

YOUR DATA HAS MORE THAN ONE OWNER

Understanding **Data Sharing**, **Hidden Partners** and Digital Privacy

DATA BROKERS | HIDDEN PARTNERS | THIRD-PARTY SHARING | PRACTICAL PRIVACY

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This book is practical guidance, not legal, security or data-protection advice. All examples, businesses and people in worked scenarios are fictional.

Contents

START HERE

Educational Disclaimer 4
Introduction: The Receipt With Forty Names 4
Who This Book Is For 5
How to Use This Book 6
The Five-Minute Data-Sharing Check 6

CHAPTERS

1. One Tap, Many Recipients 8
2. Who Receives Your Information 11
3. Cookies, Pixels and SDKs: The Plumbing of Sharing 15
4. Data Brokers: The Industry You Never Joined 19
5. Third-Party Sharing and the Language of "Partners" 23
6. Hidden Data Transfers 26
7. Putting the Pieces Together 30
8. What It Costs You 33
9. Your Rights 36
10. Share Less: Practical Protection at the Source 39
11. Pull It Back: Finding and Removing What Is Out There 43
12. If You Run a Business, You Are an Owner Too 47
13. Your 30-Day Plan 50

CLOSING

Conclusion: One Less Owner 53

APPENDICES

Appendix A: Data-Sharing Map 54
Appendix B: Rights Request Letters 55
Appendix C: The Settings Checklist 57
Appendix D: Privacy Policy Reading Guide 59
Appendix E: Removal Tracker 60

BACK MATTER

Glossary 61
A Note on GDPRGard.eu 62
About the Author 63
Notes and Sources 64

Educational Disclaimer

This book is practical, educational guidance for individuals, families, small-business owners and the people who support them. It is not legal, financial or professional privacy advice, and it does not create a professional relationship between the author and the reader.

Privacy law, company policies, app settings and the data-broker industry change quickly. Menu names and options differ between products and move over time. Check the current guidance of your national data-protection authority, the service in question, or a qualified adviser before relying on anything here for a decision that matters.

Following the steps in this book can reduce how much of your information circulates. It cannot reduce it to zero, and no tool or service can promise that it will. Where this book mentions a company, a regulator's decision or a court case, it does so as a documented example, not as a verdict on anyone's whole business.

Every person, household and business in a worked example is **fictional** and labelled as such. Real cases are sourced in the notes at the back.

Introduction: The Receipt With Forty Names

Imagine that every time you used an online service, you were handed a receipt listing everyone who received something from you.

A weather app: your location, sent to the app's maker, an analytics company, two advertising networks and a company that turns location trails into "footfall reports". A recipe site: your device details and reading habits, sent to a dozen firms you have never heard of. A fitness tracker, a loyalty card, a smart TV, a free puzzle game, a food-delivery order.

The receipt would be long. For some services, it would run to dozens of names. Most people would be surprised by who is on it.

That is the real meaning of the phrase **your data has more than one owner**. When you give information to a service, you are almost never giving it to one organisation. You are starting a chain. The service keeps a copy, its suppliers keep copies, its advertising and analytics partners keep copies, and some of those partners pass it on to others, including companies whose whole business is collecting, combining and selling information about people.

None of this is secret, exactly. Most of it is described somewhere in a privacy policy. But it is spread across thousands of words of legal text, and almost none of it is visible at the moment you tap "accept".

This book makes the receipt visible. It explains, in plain language:

- **Who receives information when you use online services,** and why.
- **How data brokers and third-party sharing work,** and what they build from the pieces.
- **How hidden data transfers happen,** across companies and across borders.
- **What you can do about it,** with practical steps that take minutes, not weekends.

You will not be asked to abandon the internet, throw away your phone or live off the grid. That is neither realistic nor necessary. The aim is smaller and more achievable: **fewer owners, chosen on purpose.**

> **The rule.** Every time you share information, ask three questions: who else gets this, what else can they do with it, and can I take it back. If you cannot answer, share less.

Who This Book Is For

This book is written for:

- **Everyday internet users** who suspect that "free" apps are paid for in some other way, and want to understand how.

- **Parents and carers** who are making decisions about children's apps, devices and school platforms.
- **Small-business owners and freelancers,** who are on both sides of this: customers of other firms' tracking tools and collectors of their own customers' data.
- **Office managers and part-time IT helpers** who are asked to "sort out the privacy side" without a legal team.
- **Anyone who has received a spam call or a scarily accurate advert** and wondered how they knew.

A word on tone. Nothing here is meant to make you feel naive or reckless. The system is designed so that sharing is the default and understanding takes effort. The people who built it are professionals; the people living with it are busy. The goal is to rebalance that a little.

How to Use This Book

You can read the book in an evening, or jump to what you need.

- **In a hurry?** Read the introduction, then Chapters 10 and 11 (practical protection) and Appendix C (the settings checklist).
- **Want to understand the machinery?** Read Chapters 1 to 6 in order. They build from a single tap to the global picture.
- **Want your data removed?** Go to Chapter 9 (your rights), Chapter 11 (pulling data back), and Appendices B and E.
- **Run a business?** Read Chapter 12 and use Appendix A to map your own data sharing.

Each chapter ends with a short action list. The appendices are designed to be printed or copied into a spreadsheet.

The Five-Minute Data-Sharing Check

Answer yes or no. Be honest; nobody is marking this.

1. Do you use at least one free app or website that you could not explain the business model of?
2. Have you ever accepted a cookie banner by pressing the biggest button without looking at the options?
3. Do any apps on your phone have access to your location "always" when you do not need it for the app to work?
4. Do you use the same email address for shopping, newsletters, social media and banking?
5. Have you ever signed up for a loyalty card for a discount without checking what it records?
6. Have you ever searched for your own name and found a site listing your address, age or relatives?
7. Do you receive marketing calls, texts or emails from firms you do not recall dealing with?
8. Do you use a smart TV, speaker, doorbell or wearable without having checked its privacy settings?
9. Do you know how to ask a company what data it holds on you?
0. Have you ever asked a company to delete your data?

Scoring. Count your **yes** answers to questions 1 to 8, then subtract one for each **yes** to questions 9 and 10 (those are good habits).

- **0 to 2:** you are in good shape. Use the book to sharpen what you already do.
- **3 to 5:** typical. You will find several quick wins in Chapters 10 and 11.
- **6 to 8:** worth an afternoon. Start with Chapter 13's 30-day plan and work through it.

CHAPTER 1

One Tap, Many Recipients

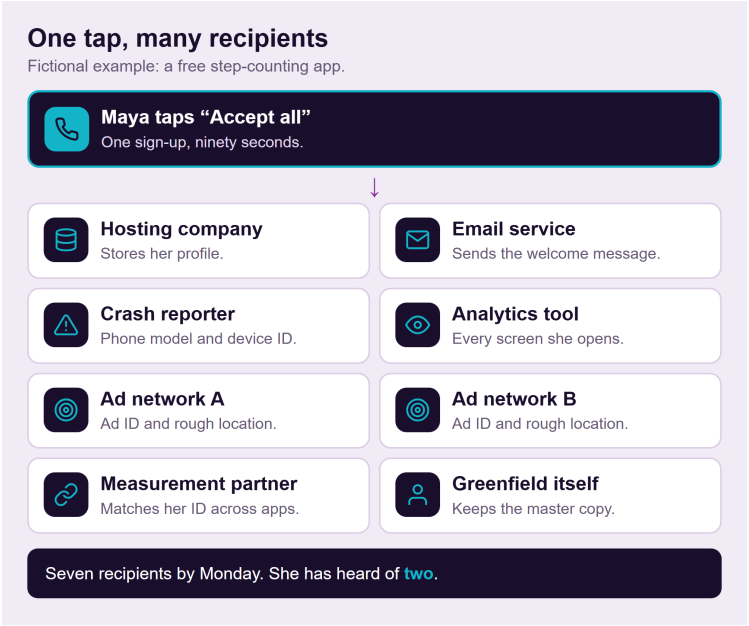
> **Fictional.** Maya, the Greenfield Steps app and every company in this story are invented. The pattern is real and common.

Maya downloads a free step-counting app on a Sunday morning. It has good reviews and a friendly icon. During sign-up she types her name, email and date of birth, taps "Allow" on a location prompt because the app says it needs it to "track your route", and taps "Accept all" on a banner she does not read.

The whole thing takes ninety seconds. Here is what happens next, in the background.

The app's maker, Greenfield, stores her profile on a cloud server run by a hosting company. Her email address goes to an email-delivery service so that Greenfield can send her a welcome message. A crash-reporting tool records her phone model, operating system and a unique device identifier. An analytics tool logs every screen she opens. Two advertising networks receive her device's advertising ID and rough location so that they can show her relevant ads inside the app. A "measurement partner" matches that ID against other apps to see whether an advert on one led to an install on another.

By Monday, Maya's step counts, routes and sign-in times are held by Greenfield and by seven outside companies. She could not name any of the seven.



One tap, many recipients: where Maya's sign-up data went

What "owner" really means

When this book says your data has more than one owner, it uses the word loosely, and it is worth being precise. In law, nobody "owns" personal data the way they own a car. What exists instead are **roles and rights**. Some organisations decide *why* and *how* your data is used. Some process it on their behalf. Some simply receive it and do their own thing. And you, the person it is about, hold rights over it that vary by country.

For everyday purposes, though, "owner" captures something true. Once a copy of your information leaves your hands, **someone else holds it, can use it, can lose it and can pass it on.** The more holders there are, the less you control any of those things.

Three ideas to carry through the book

1. Sharing is a chain, not an event. A single sign-up creates many copies. Each copy has its own life, its own security and its own policy.

2. Most sharing is invisible by design. It happens in the background of apps and web pages, between companies, in fractions of a second. You are not shown it because showing it would slow the product down and cost clicks.

3. Small pieces add up. A location here, a device ID there, an email address, a purchase. None of them feels sensitive. Together they can describe where you live, what you earn, your health, your habits and your fears. Chapter 7 covers how.

A phone lying in the dark, its glow spilling outward

What this does not mean

It does not mean every company is acting illegally. Much of this sharing is lawful, disclosed somewhere and sometimes genuinely necessary: a delivery app has to tell the restaurant your order and the courier your address. The problem is the gap between what is *necessary* to give you a service and what is *collected because it can be*.

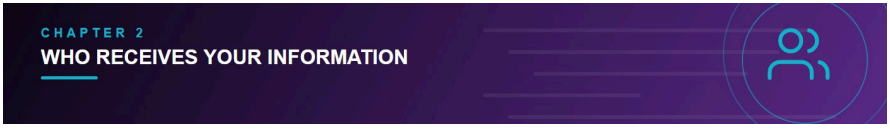
It also does not mean you should panic. Most people can cut the amount of data about them in circulation substantially with a handful of habits. That is what the second half of this book is for.

Action list

- ☐ Pick one app you use daily. Open its privacy policy and find the section on "sharing" or "partners".
- ☐ Count the categories of recipient it lists. Write the number down.
- ☐ Keep that note. You will use it in Chapter 2.

CHAPTER 2

Who Receives Your Information



Before you can reduce sharing, you need a map of who is on the receiving end. Recipients fall into a few families. Their relationship to you, and to the data, differs, and so do the rules that apply to them.

The first party: the service you chose

This is the company whose app or site you are using. It decides what to collect and why. It is the one you have a relationship with, whether you pay with money or attention. In data-protection terms it is usually the **controller**.

Service providers: the suppliers behind the curtain

Almost no service runs on its own. It rents servers, sends email through someone else, takes payments through a payment processor, uses a customer-support platform, a mapping service and an identity checker. These **processors** (or "service providers") handle data *on the first party's behalf and on its instructions*. In theory they may not use it for their own purposes.

You usually never see these companies, but they hold real copies of real data. A breach at a supplier is a breach of your information, whether or not you have heard its name.

Third parties: the ones with their own agenda

A **third party** receives data for reasons of its own. Advertising networks, analytics platforms that build cross-site profiles, social-media tracking tools, and data brokers all fall here. They are not

working for the service in the way a payment processor is; they are working for themselves, with the service as a source.

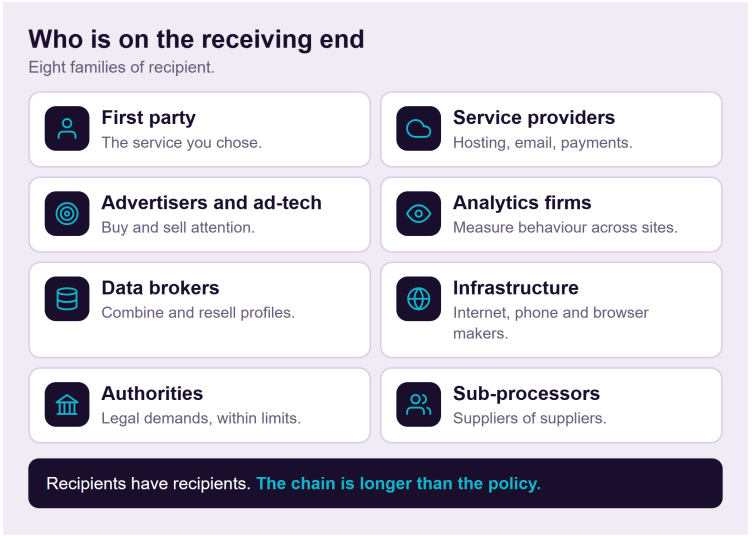
The line between "service provider" and "third party" matters because it determines what a company may do with your data and what it must tell you. It is also a line that companies sometimes blur. Always read how a company *describes* a recipient, then ask what the recipient *gets out of it*.

The infrastructure layer

Some recipients are simply in the path. Your internet provider sees which domains you visit. Your phone's operating system knows which apps you open. Your browser vendor sees sync data. A content-delivery network sees requests for the pictures on a page. These organisations may not read your content, but they see the metadata: who, when, from where, how often.

The hidden recipients: governments and courts

Law-enforcement and security agencies can require companies to hand over information, within limits that vary hugely by country. This is a smaller slice of the picture than advertising, but it explains why *where* data is held matters (Chapter 6).



The cast of recipients around a single service

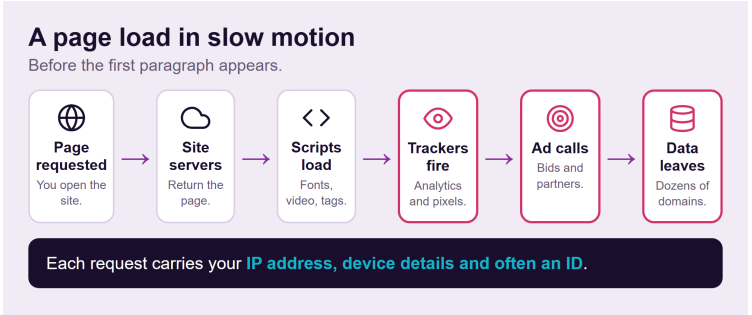
Why it is easy to lose count

Two things make the cast larger than it looks:

- **Recipients have recipients.** A processor may use sub-processors. An ad network passes data to bidders. A broker resells to other brokers. Each hop adds names you will never see.
- **Companies are generous with "partners".** A policy that says "we share data with trusted partners" can cover anything from a courier to a data marketplace.

A page load in slow motion

Visit an ordinary news or recipe site. Before the first paragraph appears, your browser may contact dozens of different domains: the site's own servers, a font provider, a video host, an analytics tool, a consent-management tool, several advertising platforms and a social-media button. Each request carries your IP address, your browser and device details and often a cookie or identifier. Many return more code, which in turn contacts more companies.



What happens in the second after a web page starts to load

You can see this yourself. Most browsers' developer tools have a "Network" tab that lists every request a page makes. It is not necessary to understand every line; counting the number of different domains is already instructive.

Action list

- ☐ Choose one site you visit daily and open the Network tab (press F12 in most browsers). Reload the page and count the distinct domains.
- ☐ Write down the three roles from this chapter that apply to your favourite app: first party, service provider, third party.
- ☐ Note any recipient on the list you cannot explain.

CHAPTER 3

Cookies, Pixels and SDKs: The Plumbing of Sharing

Most of the sharing in the last chapter is done by a small family of technologies. You do not need to be able to build them. You do need to know their names, because every privacy setting and every banner you meet is really a switch on one of them.

Fibre cables glowing in the dark: the plumbing behind every tap

Cookies

A **cookie** is a small text file a website stores in your browser. A **first-party cookie** belongs to the site you are visiting and remembers things like your login and your basket. A **third-party cookie** belongs to a different domain whose content is embedded on that page, and it can recognise you across every site that embeds the same company's code. That cross-site recognition is what made third-party cookies the backbone of online advertising for two decades.

Browser makers have restricted them to different degrees. Safari and Firefox block many by default; Chrome has changed its plans more than once. The practical lesson is that **blocking cookies reduces one kind of tracking, and the industry has long since built others.**

Pixels and tags

A **tracking pixel** is a tiny, often invisible image or script that reports back when a page or email is viewed. A site might include a pixel from a social-media company or an ad platform so that it can measure adverts and build audiences. A **tag manager** is a container that lets a marketing team add or change many such snippets without a developer. This is convenient and also how a site ends up with scripts nobody on the team can name.

Email uses the same trick. Many marketing emails contain a tiny image that records when you opened the message, from what device and roughly where. Blocking remote images in your mail app stops it.

SDKs in apps

Apps do not have cookies in the same way. Instead they embed **software development kits (SDKs)**: ready-made code libraries from other companies that provide analytics, ads, crash reports, sign-in buttons or maps. Each SDK runs inside the app with the app's permissions. If the app has your location, so can the SDK.

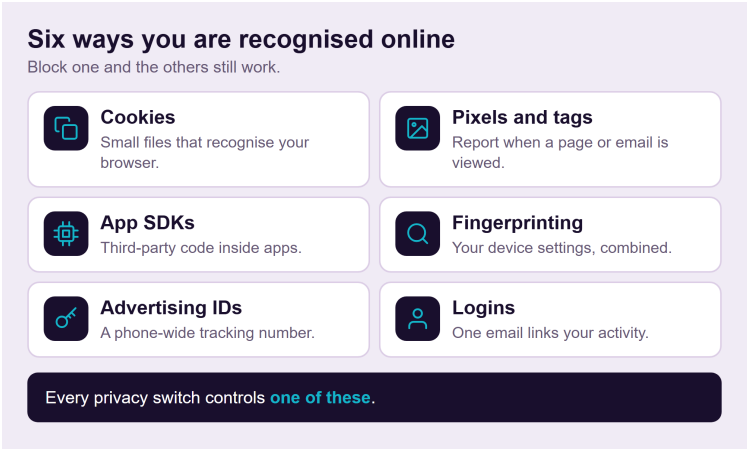
This is where the quiet sharing of apps lives. An app developer may add an SDK to earn a small fee or get free analytics, and the SDK's maker may then use the data for its own products. Researchers and regulators have repeatedly found location and device data flowing from free apps to companies that resell it.

Fingerprinting

Even with cookies blocked, a site can often recognise you by the combination of properties your device reveals: screen size, fonts, language, time zone, graphics hardware, browser version. None of it is unusual alone. Together it can be nearly unique. **Fingerprinting** is hard to block entirely, which is why privacy-focused browsers try to make many users look identical.

Advertising IDs and logins

Phones carry a resettable **advertising ID** that apps can read to link activity across apps. Users on recent versions of the major mobile operating systems can switch it off or reset it, and many apps must ask before tracking. A **login** is also a tracker: if you sign in to a service on several sites with the same email, the service, or the sites, can connect your activity under one name.

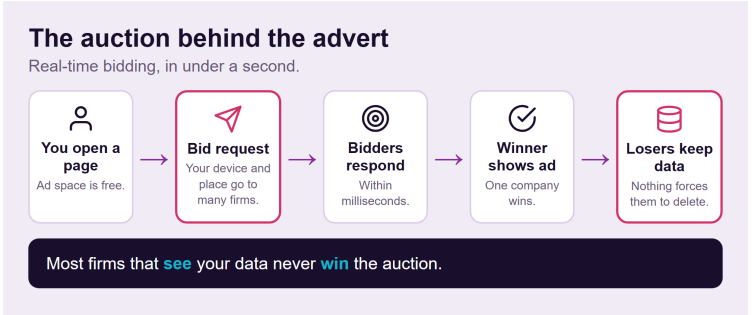


Six ways you are recognised online

Real-time bidding: the auction behind the advert

When you open a page with advertising space, a rapid auction can happen before the page finishes loading. The page's ad system sends a **bid request** describing the person about to see the ad, often including an identifier, device and browser data, page address and approximate location, to many potential advertisers. They bid, the winner's ad is shown, and the whole thing takes a fraction of a second.

The privacy problem is that the bid request is broadcast to *many* firms, most of which do not win. They can keep the information anyway. In 2022 the Irish Council for Civil Liberties published a report, based on industry data, estimating that real-time bidding exposed a typical European's online activity and location about 376 times a day, and a typical American's 747 times. The group called these figures a low estimate. It is an advocacy organisation's analysis and should be read as one, but the underlying mechanism is well documented.



The advertising auction that runs while a page loads

The European Union's top court has also weighed in. In 2024 the Court of Justice held, in a case involving the advertising-industry body IAB Europe, that the consent signal it uses in this system, called the TC string, can itself count as personal data. The decision shows how seriously the legal system now treats this machinery.

What the banner really controls

A cookie banner is usually a front end to a **consent-management platform**. "Reject all" should switch off the optional tags, and in the EU it should be as easy as "Accept all". In practice, banners vary in quality. Some bury the reject option; some set tags before you answer. A good rule: if the option to refuse needs more clicks than the option to accept, that is a design choice, and often a legal problem for the site.

Action list

- ☐ In your phone settings, find the advertising ID control and reset it or turn off personalised ads.
- ☐ In your mail app, switch on "block remote images" or "protect mail activity".
- ☐ Next time you see a cookie banner, click "Reject all" or "Manage" and see what it offers. Count the clicks.

CHAPTER 4

Data Brokers: The Industry You Never Joined

Most people have a clear idea of who they do business with. Data brokers are the exception: companies whose product is information *about* you, who have no relationship with you, and whom you will probably never meet.

What a data broker is

A **data broker** collects personal information from many sources, combines and analyses it, and sells or licenses the result to other organisations. The category is broad. Some brokers sell lists of consumers who match marketing criteria. Some run "people-search" websites that publish names, addresses, ages and relatives. Some provide risk, fraud and identity-verification scores. Some sell location trails or audience segments to advertisers. Some do several of these.

Rows of identical cabinets, each holding hundreds of small items: every one a record about someone

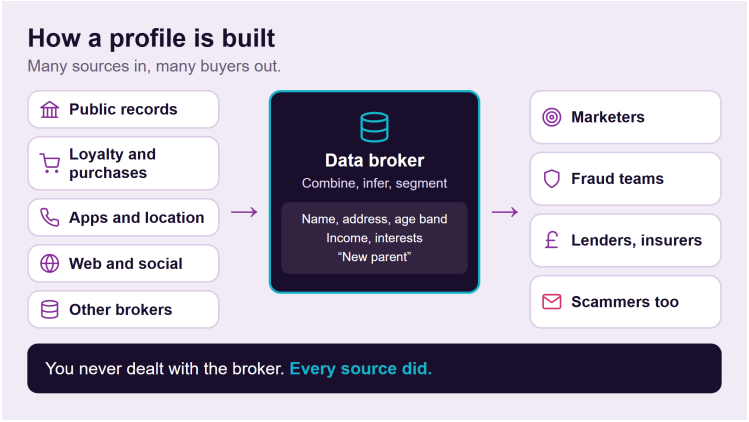
Where the information comes from

Brokers rarely collect directly. They assemble data from:

- **Public records:** property and court records, electoral rolls where available, business registrations, professional licences.
- **Commercial sources:** loyalty-card and purchase data, warranty and survey forms, subscription lists, retailers and publishers that sell or share customer files.
- **Online and app data:** cookies, device IDs, SDK data, location signals and browsing records, bought from apps, ad-tech firms and other brokers.
- **Social media and other public web pages,** collected at scale.
- **Other brokers.** Much of the industry is brokers buying from, and selling to, each other, which is why one removal rarely finishes the job.

What they build

The raw material is combined into profiles. A profile may hold basic facts (name, address, age range, household), inferred traits (income band, education, family status, interests) and behaviours (shops visited, apps used, places frequented). Brokers then sell **segments** with labels like "new parent", "frequent traveller", "likely to switch broadband" or less comfortable ones relating to health, finances or vulnerability.



How a profile is built and who buys it

Who buys

- **Marketers** who want to reach, or exclude, certain groups.

- **Retailers and publishers** that enrich their customer files.
- **Fraud and identity teams** that verify who someone is.
- **Insurers, lenders and landlords,** in some jurisdictions and uses, where the law allows.
- **Researchers, investigators and journalists.**
- **Scammers.** People-search data and marketing lists are also useful to people who want to impersonate, harass or defraud. A list of retirees who respond to prize draws is valuable to the wrong buyer.

Cases that made the news

Regulators have acted on several documented examples:

- **Avast and Jumpshot.** In 2024 the US Federal Trade Commission announced a settlement of $16.5 million with the antivirus company Avast. The agency alleged that Avast collected consumers' browsing data through its software and sold it through a subsidiary, Jumpshot, to more than 100 third parties, despite promising to protect users from tracking. The order required Avast to delete the data and barred it from selling browsing data for advertising.
- **Location-data brokers.** The FTC has also taken action against companies that collected or sold precise location data, including X-Mode (later Outlogic), InMarket, Kochava and Gravy Analytics, with orders limiting the sale of sensitive location data such as visits to health clinics or places of worship.
- **Ad-tech in Europe.** French regulator CNIL fined the advertising company Criteo €40 million in 2023 for consent and transparency failures in its tracking and profiling.

These are alleged practices and regulatory findings in specific matters, not a claim about every firm in the industry. They show something practical: **the category is real, regulated and enforceable, and the data involved is often more intimate than people expect.**

"But the data is anonymous"

Companies often say their data is "anonymised" or "de-identified". Sometimes that is true. Often it means that names were removed while a persistent device ID, home location or purchase pattern was left in, which can be enough to identify someone. The Avast complaint is a documented example where re-identification was a concern. Chapter 7 explains why.

Brokers and the law

The rules differ widely:

- **European Union and United Kingdom.** Brokers handling personal data need a lawful basis, must be transparent and must honour your rights, including access, erasure and objection to direct marketing. Detail is in Chapter 9.
- **United States.** There is no single federal privacy law. A growing set of state laws, led by California, let residents opt out of the sale or sharing of data. A few states require data brokers to register publicly. California's Delete Act created a central deletion tool, called DROP, which since August 2026 requires registered brokers to retrieve and process deletion requests from the state's system at regular intervals.
- **Elsewhere.** Rules vary from strong to almost none.

Action list

- ☐ Search for your own full name plus your town in a search engine. Note which people-search sites list you.
- ☐ Do not pay anyone to "remove" you yet. Chapter 11 covers how to do it for free.
- ☐ Write down which of the profile sources above apply to you.

CHAPTER 5

Third-Party Sharing and the Language of "Partners"

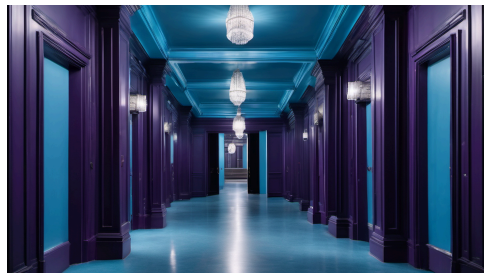
Chapter 4 covered companies that trade in data. This chapter covers the ordinary businesses you deal with, and the ways they share information with others.

The legal vocabulary

Three phrases appear in nearly every privacy policy:

- **"Service providers" or "processors"** act on the company's instructions. In theory they cannot use the data for themselves.
- **"Partners," "affiliates" or "third parties"** may use the data for their own purposes. Affiliates are sister companies in the same group.
- **"Sale" and "sharing."** Under California-style laws, a "sale" is an exchange of personal information for money or other valuable consideration. "Sharing" means disclosing it for cross-context behavioural advertising. The law gives you a right to opt out of both.

Under EU and UK rules, the key question is who decides the **purposes and means** of the processing. Two companies who decide together can be **joint controllers.** In a 2019 case involving the fashion retailer Fashion ID, the EU Court of Justice held that a website that embeds a social-media plug-in, which sends visitors' data to the social network, can be a joint controller with the network for that collection and disclosure. In plain terms: *embedding someone else's code is a data-sharing decision, and the site is responsible for it.*



A long corridor of identical doors: each one a company with its own copy

How to read a privacy policy in five minutes

Policies are long on purpose, but the same parts recur. You can answer most of your questions by finding five headings:

1. **What we collect.** Look for categories beyond what you typed in: device data, location, "inferences".
2. **Why we use it.** Look for "marketing", "personalisation", "analytics", "research" and "improving our services", which can hide a great deal.
3. **Who we share it with.** Look for named categories: advertising partners, analytics providers, affiliates, "business partners".
4. **International transfers.** Where is it sent, and on what legal footing?
5. **Your choices.** Find the opt-out link and the contact for rights requests.

Policy phrase decoder

What common wording can mean.

"Trusted partners"	Anyone from a courier to a data marketplace. Ask for categories.
"We do not sell your data"	Check the definition. Sharing for ads may be described differently.
"Aggregated" or "de-identified"	Is an ID, location or birth date still in the file?
"To improve your experience"	Often means profiling or ad targeting.
"In a merger or sale"	Your data can change owners with the company.

Vague wording is a **reason to ask**, not a reason to assume the worst.

A policy phrase decoder: what common wording can mean

Warning phrases

- **"We may share data with selected partners."** Ask who and for what. A reputable policy lists categories.
- **"We do not sell your personal information."** Check the definition of "sell". Sharing for advertising may be described differently and still happen.
- **"Aggregated" or "de-identified" data.** Ask whether an ID, location or date of birth stays in the file.
- **"We may transfer data in a merger or sale of the business."** Your data can change owners with the company.
- **"To improve your experience."** Often means profiling.

Mergers, bankruptcies and bought customer files

Customer data is an asset. When a firm is sold, merged or goes bust, its customer files can be sold with it. Regulators in several countries have said that promises made to customers still apply to the buyer. In practice, you may find yourself the customer of a company you never chose.

Sharing you actively invite

Not all sharing is hidden. Some you do yourself: "Sign in with" a social account, linking a bank to a budgeting tool, granting a quiz app access to your contacts, or clicking "allow" on a photo-editing app that asks for your whole library. Each connection can persist for years after you stop using the app, and it keeps working like any other standing permission.

Action list

- ☐ Find the "connected apps" or "apps with access" page for your main email or social account. Remove anything you do not use.
- ☐ Open one privacy policy and find all five headings above.
- ☐ Write down any phrase you cannot explain, and ask the company what it means.

CHAPTER 6

Hidden Data Transfers

Data does not stay where you typed it. It moves between companies, between servers and between countries, usually without anything on your screen to say so.

Three kinds of movement

Between companies. Everything in Chapters 2 to 5: suppliers, advertisers, brokers.

Between systems. A company copies your data into other systems: a customer-service tool, a marketing platform, a data warehouse, a test environment, an AI service. Each copy has its own access list.

Between countries. Many services store and process data in several jurisdictions. Customer support may be in one country, the servers in another, the analytics in a third.

Light trails between districts at night: data crosses borders the same way

Why borders matter

Different countries give very different protection to personal data, and different governments have different powers to demand it. The EU's GDPR therefore restricts transfers of personal data out of the

European Economic Area unless an approved safeguard applies:

- **Adequacy decisions,** where the European Commission has found a country's protection broadly equivalent.
- **Standard contractual clauses (SCCs),** approved contract terms between exporter and importer, usually backed by an assessment of the destination country's laws.
- **Binding corporate rules** for transfers within a corporate group.
- **Narrow exceptions,** such as explicit consent for a specific transfer.

The UK has its own parallel system.

The EU-US story

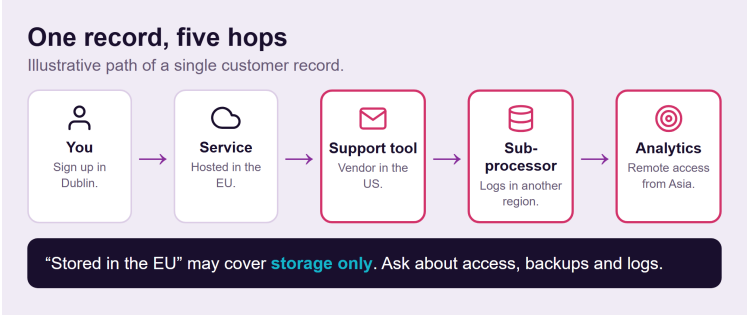
Transfers to the United States have been the most contested. The Court of Justice struck down two earlier frameworks, Safe Harbour in 2015 and Privacy Shield in 2020, because of concerns about US surveillance law. The current EU-US Data Privacy Framework was adopted by the European Commission in July 2023. In September 2025 the EU General Court dismissed a challenge to it, and the applicant appealed to the Court of Justice later that year. At the time of writing, the framework remains in force while the appeal is pending, so the position could change. If your work depends on it, check the current status.

The point for ordinary people is simple: **the legal footing for sending European data to the US has been unstable for a decade, and it is still being tested.**

Fines that show what regulators look for

- **Meta, €1.2 billion (2023).** The Irish Data Protection Commission fined Meta Platforms Ireland for transferring European users' data to the United States on the basis of standard contractual clauses without adequate supplementary protection.
- **TikTok, €530 million (2025).** The same regulator fined TikTok for transferring European users' data to China without ensuring protection essentially equivalent to EU law, and for transparency failings. TikTok said it would appeal.

These are the regulators' findings in specific cases and the companies have contested aspects of them. They are included because they show that cross-border transfers are an enforcement priority, not a technicality.



The chain of hidden hops behind one customer record

Sub-processors: the hops you do not see

A company that uses a processor is usually allowed to let that processor use **sub-processors,** often listed in a document on its website. A support platform may use a cloud host; the cloud host may use a monitoring tool; the monitoring tool may use a log service. A single customer record can end up touched by five or six organisations in several countries.

When a company says your data stays in the EU, ask what it means. Does it cover storage only? Does support staff elsewhere have remote access? Which backups, logs and analytics are included?

AI services: a new hop

Many products now send text, images or audio to an AI provider to be processed or summarised. That is another recipient, sometimes in another country, and the rules about whether your content is stored or used for training differ by provider and by plan. Check a service's AI section, and be cautious about what you paste into tools you do not control.

What you can do

You cannot audit every sub-processor. You can:

- Prefer services that publish a clear list of processors and transfer safeguards.
- Check where a service says it stores data and who can access it.
- Be sparing with highly sensitive information in services that cannot tell you.
- Use your rights (Chapter 9) to ask where your data went.

Action list

- ☐ Find the "sub-processors" or "data transfers" page of one service you pay for.
- ☐ Note the countries listed.
- ☐ If the answer is "we do not say", write to ask. Keep the reply.

CHAPTER 7

Putting the Pieces Together

The reassuring thing people say about data is, "They only have my email address," or "It's only my location," or "It's just what I bought." Each is a small thing. The power of the data economy is that small things combine.

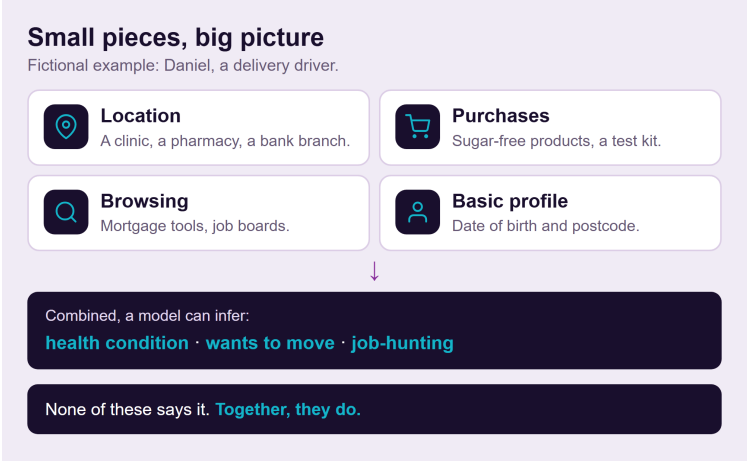
The mosaic effect

Intelligence analysts talk about a **mosaic**: individually harmless tiles that reveal a picture when laid side by side. Data works the same way.

> **Fictional.** Daniel, a delivery driver, has never told any company he is saving for a house, managing a health condition or looking for a new job. Yet a profile built from public and purchased data could suggest all three.

- His phone's location shows a weekly visit to a clinic, a pharmacy and a bank branch.
- A loyalty card records purchases of sugar-free products and a blood-glucose test.
- His browsing includes mortgage calculators and job boards.
- A free app has his date of birth and postcode.

No single source says "this man has diabetes, wants to move and is thinking of changing jobs." Combined, a model can infer it, with enough confidence to sell a segment.



Small pieces, big picture: how harmless data points combine

Identification from small facts

A classic study by the researcher Latanya Sweeney in the early 2000s estimated that 87% of the US population could be uniquely identified by just a five-digit postcode, date of birth and sex. Later analyses found lower but still large figures. The lesson: **a handful of ordinary attributes can single out one person in a crowd of millions.**

That is why "we removed your name" is a weak promise. Location data is even more revealing. A trail of where a phone sleeps at night and where it goes during the day usually identifies a household in a few steps, because there is typically only one home address per phone.

Inference: facts you never gave

Systems now routinely produce **inferred data:** guesses about your income, health, relationships, politics, religion, sexuality, pregnancy or mental state, drawn from behaviour. Inferences may be wrong, but they can be acted on as if they were true: an advert shown, a price offered, a loan flagged.

Under the GDPR, inferences about identifiable people are still personal data, and if they reveal special categories such as health or beliefs, extra rules apply. In practice, few people know what has been inferred about them.

Why combination also helps attackers

The same joining of data that powers advertising makes fraud easier. A scammer with your name, phone number, date of birth, employer and recent purchases can write a message that sounds exactly like your bank or courier. Breached data from one company is matched against broker data from another to fill in blanks.

Scattered puzzle pieces: individually meaningless, together a picture

What breaks the mosaic

You cannot remove every tile, but you can make the picture blurrier:

- **Separate identities.** Use different email addresses (or aliases) for banking, shopping and social media so they cannot be joined by an email match.
- **Limit persistent IDs.** Reset your advertising ID; use browsers that limit cross-site tracking.
- **Withhold the high-value tiles.** Date of birth, home postcode and phone number are the glue. Give them only where they are truly required.

Action list

- ☐ Look at the last three forms you filled in. Mark every field that was not necessary.
- ☐ List three places where you gave your real date of birth. Could a year, or nothing, have done?
- ☐ Create a second email alias for shopping and newsletters.

CHAPTER 8

What It Costs You

If data sharing were harmless, none of this would matter. Some of it is harmless, and some of it is not. The costs fall in different places.

Money and fairness

Price and offer differences. Companies use profiles to decide which offers to show you and sometimes which prices. Dynamic pricing is legitimate when based on demand; it becomes uncomfortable when based on what a profile says you will tolerate. Regulators in several countries have looked at personalised pricing, and rules differ. Where you cannot see the basis, you cannot challenge it.

Credit, insurance and housing. In some places, data from non-traditional sources can feed risk models. The rules for what may be used vary, and some uses are banned or restricted. Mistakes in a file can follow you for years.

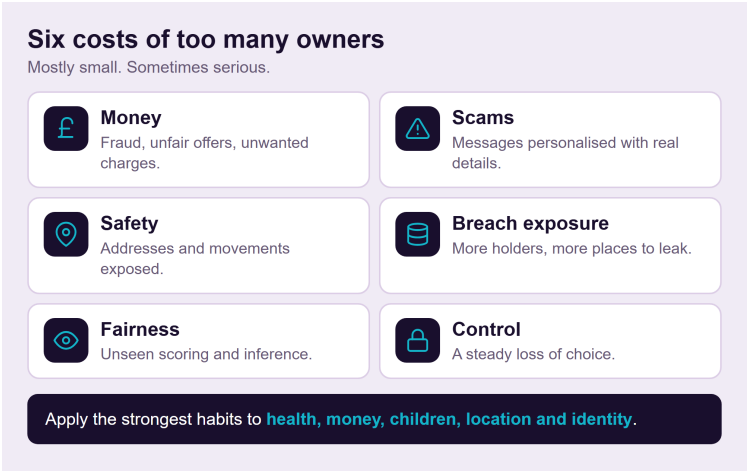
Safety and harassment

People-search sites can expose a home address and a list of relatives. For most people that is a nuisance. For people fleeing abuse, working in public-facing jobs or experiencing stalking, it can be dangerous. Several US states and other jurisdictions allow some residents to have addresses suppressed or removed for safety reasons.

Location data has been used to track visits to sensitive places. Regulators have acted on sales of such data, and journalists have shown how a purchased dataset can reveal an individual's movements.

Scams and fraud

Scams are more persuasive when personalised. Phone numbers, family names, recent purchases and employer details come from breaches and brokers, and they make a fake message feel real. Older people and busy parents are frequent targets of lists built for exactly that purpose. Fraud that begins with a convincing message is often fuelled by data that was legitimately collected somewhere along the line.



Six costs of too many data owners

The breach multiplier

Every holder of your data is a place it can be lost. A breach does not depend on how much you trusted the first company; it depends on the weakest holder in the chain. The more copies exist, the more chances there are for one to leak, be stolen or be sold. A supplier you have never heard of can expose your email, address and purchase history.

Autonomy and trust

There is a quieter cost: the feeling of being watched, and the practical effect of it. People change what they search for, say and read when they suspect it is recorded. Some cannot opt out without losing access to services they rely on. A fair summary: **the cost is not usually one dramatic event, but a steady loss of control.**

A sense of proportion

It is worth being honest about scale. For most people, most of the time, the day-to-day cost is more spam, more targeted ads and some unease. The serious harms are less frequent but real, and they cluster around vulnerable people and sensitive data. That is a good reason to apply the strongest habits to the most sensitive categories: health, finances, children, location and identity.

What this means for the rest of the book

Because costs vary, you do not need to treat every piece of data the same way. Chapters 10 and 11 group actions by impact and effort. Start with the steps that cut the most exposure for the least work.

Action list

- ☐ Rank the data you share from most to least sensitive: health, finances, location, children, identity, interests.
- ☐ Tick the categories where you would feel real harm if exposed.
- ☐ Use that ranking to choose your first three actions in Chapter 13.

CHAPTER 9

Your Rights

You are not powerless. In many countries, the law gives you real tools. Using them is easier than most people expect, and the letters in Appendix B do most of the work.

A dark building at night with a few windows lit: who is looking in?

Under the GDPR and UK GDPR

If you are in the European Economic Area or the UK, you have these main rights over personal data that organisations hold about you:

- **Access (Article 15).** Ask for a copy of your data and information about how it is used, who receives it and where it came from.
- **Rectification (Article 16).** Correct inaccurate data.
- **Erasure (Article 17).** Ask for deletion in specified circumstances, such as when the data is no longer needed or you withdraw consent.
- **Restriction (Article 18).** Ask a company to pause using your data while a dispute is resolved.
- **Portability (Article 20).** Receive certain data in a usable format, or have it sent to another provider.
- **Objection (Article 21).** Object to processing based on legitimate interests, and **absolutely** to direct marketing, including profiling for it.

- **Automated decisions (Article 22).** Protection in certain solely automated decisions with significant effects.
- **Withdrawing consent (Article 7).** It must be as easy to withdraw as to give.

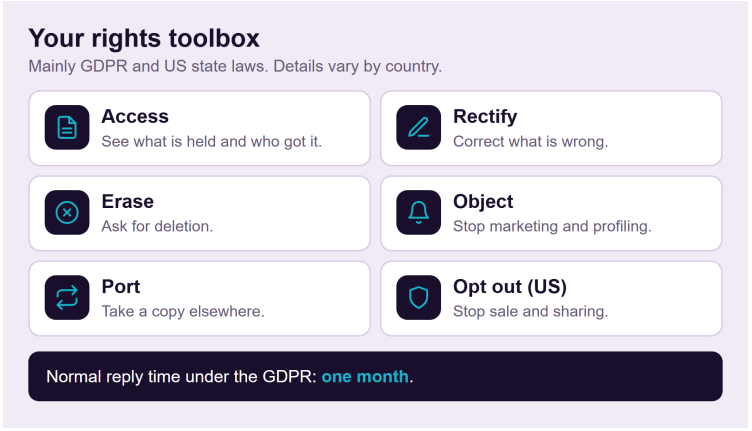
Companies must normally respond **within one month,** extendable in complex cases. They cannot charge a fee for ordinary requests. They may ask for proof of identity.

Under US state laws

Several US states have comprehensive privacy laws. Details differ, but the typical rights are to know and access data, to correct and delete it, and to **opt out of sale, targeted advertising and some profiling.** California's laws are the best known. Some states require companies to honour browser-level opt-out signals, such as **Global Privacy Control (GPC),** which you can switch on in some browsers or through an extension.

Elsewhere

Many other countries, including Brazil, Canada, South Korea, Japan, India and several in Africa and Asia, have comprehensive privacy laws. Rights differ, so check your national regulator's website.



Your rights toolbox and when to use each tool

Making a request that works

1. **Find the right contact.** Look in the privacy policy for a data-protection officer or a rights-request form or email address.
2. **Be specific.** Say what you want: a copy, deletion, an end to marketing.
3. **Name the law.** "Under Article 15 of the GDPR" or "Under the CCPA" signals you know what you are asking for.
4. **Keep records.** Note the date, keep the reply, and diarise the deadline.
5. **Ask about recipients.** The right of access includes who the data was shared with. This is the best way to uncover the parties in Chapters 2 to 6.
6. **Escalate.** If the company does not respond or answers poorly, you can complain to your data-protection authority, which is free.

Limits and honest expectations

- Companies may refuse in some circumstances, for example where they have a legal duty to keep data. They should tell you why.
- Deletion does not always reach every copy immediately; backups and legal retention can delay it.
- Rights apply to the company you ask. They do not automatically reach brokers who bought the data. You must ask each.
- Some companies make the process harder than the law intends. Persist politely and keep records.

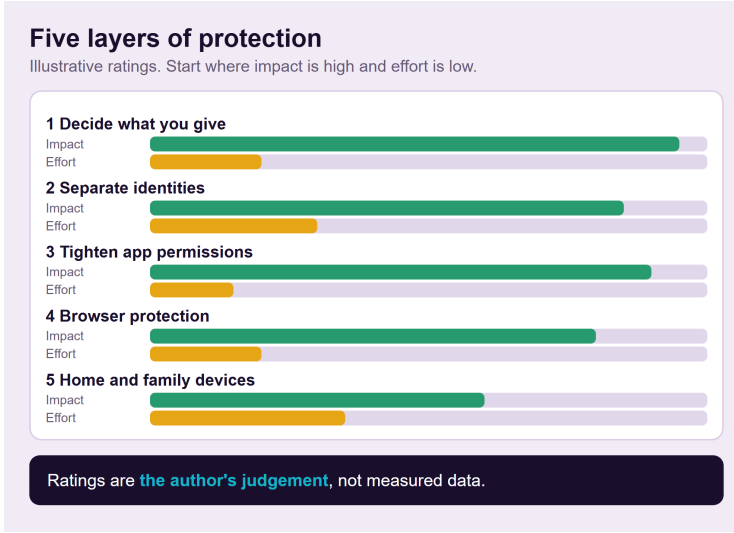
Action list

- ☐ Choose one service that holds a lot of your data. Send an access request using Appendix B.
- ☐ Put a reminder in your calendar for 30 days later.
- ☐ If you are in a US state with a privacy law, switch on a browser or extension that sends the Global Privacy Control signal.

CHAPTER 10

Share Less: Practical Protection at the Source

The most effective privacy step is the oldest: do not hand over what you do not need to. Every piece of data you never give is a piece that cannot be shared, sold, breached or combined.



Five layers of protection, from the source outwards

Layer 1: Decide what you give

Before signing up, ask three questions:

1. **Is this service worth my data?** For a one-off use, consider whether you can avoid an account entirely, by using "continue as guest".
2. **What is the minimum it needs?** Optional fields are optional. Many forms mark them poorly; leave them blank first and see what happens.

3. **Is there a version with less?** Many services have a paid or "lite" tier with less advertising and tracking.

Layer 2: Separate your identities

A single email address is a master key that lets different companies, and brokers, link your activity.

- Use **email aliases** or "hide my email" features so each service sees a different address. If one starts sending spam or is breached, you can shut off that alias.
- Use a separate address for finance and official accounts that you never use for newsletters or shops.
- Consider a **virtual card** for subscriptions and trials, where your bank or card issuer offers them.
- Use a **password manager** and unique passwords, so a breach at one company does not unlock the others.

Layer 3: Tighten phone and app permissions

Phones are the richest data source most people carry. Spend ten minutes on these controls:

- **Location:** set apps to "While using" or "Never". "Always" is rarely needed outside navigation, safety or family-sharing apps. Turn off precise location where a rough area will do.
- **Contacts, photos, microphone, camera, calendar:** remove access from anything that does not obviously need it.
- **Tracking:** on iPhone, switch off "Allow Apps to Request to Track" to refuse every request automatically. On Android, delete or reset the advertising ID and turn off ad personalisation.
- **Delete what you do not use.** An installed app that you never open can still be sending data.
- **Review "Privacy dashboard" or "Privacy report"** screens in your phone settings, which show recent permission use.

Layer 4: Browser and web habits

- **Use a browser with strong tracking protection** and keep it updated. Safari, Firefox, Brave and others block more tracking by default than a plain setup.
- **Block third-party cookies** and consider a reputable content blocker. Be selective: install few extensions, because extensions themselves can read your browsing, as the Avast case showed.
- **Switch on Global Privacy Control** where available.
- **Reject optional cookies** on banners. Use "Manage" rather than "Accept all".
- **Separate profiles or containers** for shopping, social media and work help stop cross-site linkage.
- **Search privately** when you can: some search engines do not build a profile from your queries.
- **Be cautious with "Sign in with" buttons.** They are convenient and also connect your accounts.

Layer 5: Devices in your home and pocket

Smart TVs, speakers, doorbells, cars and wearables collect more than most owners realise.

- During setup, **decline** optional data sharing, viewing-data collection and voice-recording storage.
- Find the setting often named "**viewing information**", "**interest-based ads**" or "**automatic content recognition**" on TVs and turn it off.
- Put smart-home devices on a **guest network.**
- Check whether a car's connected services share driving data with insurers or data partners, and opt out if you can.
- Before selling or giving away any device, **factory-reset it** and remove it from your account.

Children and family

- Review settings for each child's device and apps; many apps have separate children's privacy modes.

- Talk about what is shared in games, chat and school platforms.
- Remember that a **photo posted of a child** is also shared data, often with location metadata in the file.
- If a school or club asks for broad consent, ask what is shared and with whom. You are entitled to ask.

A word about trade-offs

Every step has a cost in convenience. A guest checkout is slower, a hidden email is one more thing to manage and a browser without cross-site tracking will occasionally break a page. Choose the steps you will actually keep. A small set done consistently beats a perfect set abandoned in a week.

Action list

- ☐ Set location to "While using" or "Never" for every app that does not need it.
- ☐ Create an alias or second email for shops and newsletters and use it for your next sign-up.
- ☐ Switch your main browser to a strict tracking-protection setting.

CHAPTER 11

Pull It Back: Finding and Removing What Is Out There

Chapter 10 reduces what flows out from now on. This chapter deals with what is already in circulation. The honest summary: you can remove a lot, you cannot remove everything, and it is a recurring job, not a one-off.

A door almost closed: removal is a routine, not a one-off

Step 1: See what exists

- **Search yourself.** Use your name with your town, your phone number and your email address, in quotation marks. Note every site that lists you.
- **Use search-engine tools.** Some search engines offer a tool to request removal of results containing personal contact details or home address. They remove the *result*, not the source page.
- **Check breach history.** A breach-notification service can tell you which breaches involved your email address, which indicates which companies hold, or lost, your data.
- **Request your data.** Send access requests (Chapter 9) to the main services you use, and to a few brokers.

Step 2: Remove at the source

For each site that holds your information:

1. Look for an **opt-out, "do not sell", "remove my information"** or **privacy request** link, usually in the footer.
2. Follow the process. It often requires your email and sometimes a verification step. Use a separate alias if you can.
3. Record the date, the site and the confirmation.
4. Re-check in 30 to 60 days. Entries often reappear when a broker re-imports from another source.

For people-search sites, the instructions differ for each, and some are deliberately tedious. That is why a tracker (Appendix E) helps.

Step 3: Use the legal levers

- **EEA/UK:** send an erasure request and an objection to marketing under Chapter 9. If the company says it has no data, ask it to confirm in writing and to say whether it has received data from other sources.
- **California:** residents can use the state's DROP system, run by the California Privacy Protection Agency, to send one deletion request to all registered data brokers. Since August 2026, brokers have had to check for and process requests regularly, and financial penalties apply for failures. Other states are watching and some have similar plans.
- **Other US states:** use the opt-out links that privacy-law states require, and the Global Privacy Control signal.

Step 4: Think carefully before paying a removal service

Commercial services offer to remove you from many broker sites for a subscription. They can save time, but consider:

- **They only cover the brokers they know about,** and they must repeat the work because data returns.
- **You give them personal data to do it,** so you are trusting another company. Check its own privacy policy first.

- **Free routes exist** for most of what they do.

A reasonable approach: do the highest-priority sites yourself, and consider a service only if time is the bigger problem than money.

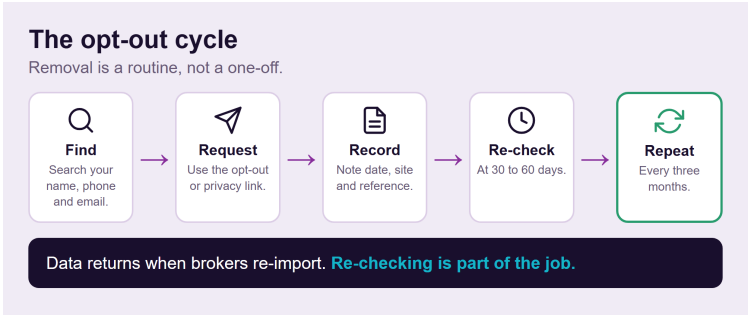
Step 5: Clean your own accounts

- **Delete old accounts.** Services you have not used in years still hold data. Search your email for "welcome" and "verify your email" to find them. Close the accounts and request deletion, not just deactivation.
- **Review connected apps** on your main email and social accounts and remove stale ones.
- **Check ad settings** on the big platforms. Most have a page where you can see and delete the interests they assigned to you and switch off personalised ads.
- **Review location history, voice recordings and search history** in your main account and set auto-delete.

Step 6: Make it a habit

Set two reminders:

- **Every three months:** re-run your self-search, re-check the top removals and review app permissions.
- **Once a year:** do a full account clean-up and read your phone's privacy report.



The opt-out cycle: find, request, record, re-check

When it is more serious

If your address is circulating and you have safety concerns, such as stalking or domestic abuse, contact a specialist support organisation. They can advise on safe suppression of records, address-confidentiality programmes where they exist and the reporting of harassment. Do not rely on a self-help list alone.

Action list

- ☐ Search your name, phone and email in quotation marks. List every site that shows them.
- ☐ Submit removal requests to the top three, and record them in Appendix E.
- ☐ Close two old accounts you no longer use.

CHAPTER 12

If You Run a Business, You Are an Owner Too

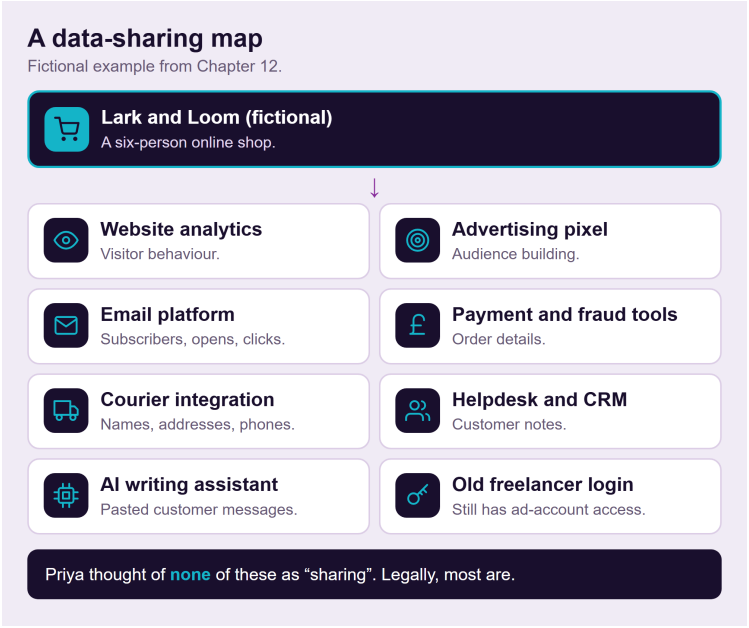
Up to now this book has looked at data from the side of the person it describes. If you run a business, even a one-person one, you are also on the other side: you collect customers' data, you pass it to suppliers and you may install tracking tools on your website. Your customers are in Maya's position.

Where your own sharing hides

> **Fictional.** Lark and Loom is a six-person online homeware shop. The owner, Priya, believes the business "only keeps names and addresses for deliveries". A one-hour review finds more.

- The **website** loads an analytics tool, an advertising pixel, a chat widget, a review plug-in, a video embed and a map. Each sends visitor data to its provider.
- The **email platform** tracks opens and clicks and stores subscribers' details on servers abroad.
- The **payment and fraud tools** pass order details to their providers.
- The **courier integration** shares names, addresses and phone numbers with delivery firms.
- The **CRM and helpdesk** hold customer notes; the helpdesk vendor uses sub-processors.
- An **AI writing assistant** has been used to draft replies containing real customer messages.
- A **former freelancer** still has a shared login to the advertising account.

Priya had, quite honestly, not thought of most of these as "sharing". Legally, most are.



A data-sharing map for a small online business

The five jobs of an honest data owner

1. Map it. List every tool that touches personal data: what it receives, why, where it is stored and who the vendor is. Appendix A is a template.

2. Minimise it. For every field you collect, ask whether you would miss it if you stopped. Remove tags, pixels and plug-ins you do not use. Fewer tools mean fewer owners.

3. Contract it. Where a vendor processes data for you, you need a written **data-processing agreement** covering instructions, security, sub-processors and deletion. Most reputable vendors publish one. Where a vendor uses data for its own purposes, you may need to treat it as a separate controller or joint controller and tell your customers.

4. Tell people. Your privacy notice should list the categories of recipient, the purposes and any transfers outside the EEA or UK, in plain language. It should match reality. A notice that was copied from a template and never updated is a liability.

5. Respect choices. Cookie banners must work: optional tags must not fire before consent, and refusing must be as easy as accepting. Honour objections to marketing and access or deletion requests within the legal time limit.

Transfers and tools: a quick test

For each vendor, ask:

- Does it use our data for its own purposes?
- Where is data stored and who can access it from abroad?
- What transfer mechanism covers it: an adequacy decision, SCCs or the Data Privacy Framework?
- What happens to the data if we stop using it?
- Does it use AI services, and is our data used for training?

If a vendor cannot answer, it is either a red flag or a sign that you need a different vendor.

Customer trust as a selling point

Privacy work is not only a cost. Customers increasingly prefer shops that say plainly what they collect and make deletion easy. For help, see the GDPRGard note at the back of the book.

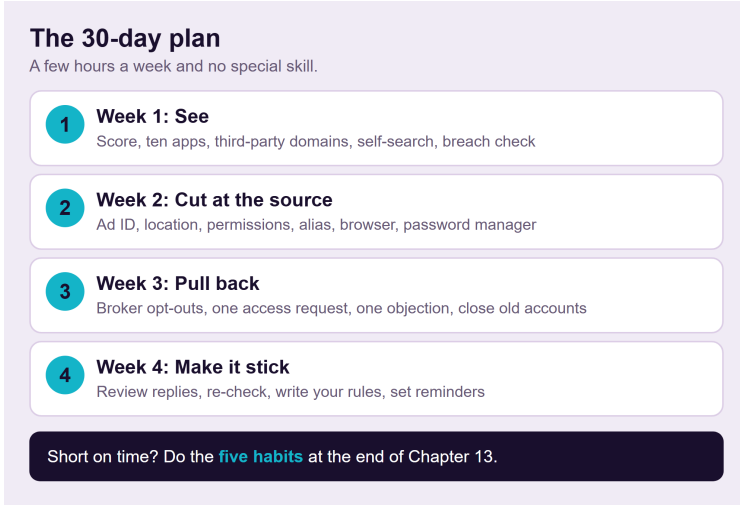
Action list

- ☐ Open your website in a browser's Network tab and count the third-party domains. Remove any you cannot justify.
- ☐ Fill in Appendix A for your five most-used tools.
- ☐ Check that your privacy notice names the categories of recipient you found.

CHAPTER 13

Your 30-Day Plan

Knowledge is only useful if it changes something. This plan assumes a few hours a week and no special skill. Do the steps in order; each builds on the last.



The 30-day plan at a glance

Week 1: See

- **Day 1:** Take the Five-Minute Data-Sharing Check at the front of the book and write down your score.
- **Day 2:** List your ten most-used apps and sites. Next to each, note what it asks for: location, contacts, email, payment.
- **Day 3:** Do the Chapter 2 exercise: count the third-party domains on one site you use daily.
- **Day 4:** Search yourself (Chapter 11, step 1) and list what you find.
- **Day 5:** Check your email addresses in a breach-notification service.

- **Day 6 to 7:** Read the privacy policy of your most-used app using the five headings in Chapter 5.

Week 2: Cut at the source

- **Day 8:** Reset your advertising ID and switch off personalised ads.
- **Day 9:** Go through location permissions on your phone. Set most to "While using" or "Never".
- **Day 10:** Review camera, microphone, contacts and photos permissions.
- **Day 11:** Create an alias and use it for the next three sign-ups. Start moving old shopping accounts to it.
- **Day 12:** Switch your browser to strict tracking protection and enable Global Privacy Control.
- **Day 13:** Set up a password manager if you have not, and change the passwords of your top five accounts.
- **Day 14:** Check smart TV and home-device privacy settings.

Week 3: Pull back

- **Day 15 to 16:** Submit removal requests to the top three people-search sites on your list.
- **Day 17:** Send one access request (Appendix B) to a service that holds a lot of your data.
- **Day 18:** Send one objection to direct marketing to a company that keeps contacting you.
- **Day 19:** Close three old accounts, requesting deletion.
- **Day 20:** Remove unused connected apps from your email and social accounts.
- **Day 21:** If you are in California, submit a DROP request; elsewhere, use available opt-out links.

Week 4: Make it stick

- **Day 22:** Review the replies you have received. Record them in the tracker.
- **Day 23:** Re-check what remains from your first search.

- **Day 24 to 25:** If you run a business, map your tools (Appendix A) and remove unused tags.
- **Day 26:** Review your children's or family members' devices, if relevant.
- **Day 27:** Write your own short data-sharing rules, such as "no real birth date unless required".
- **Day 28:** Put the quarterly and annual reminders in your calendar.
- **Day 29:** Retake the Five-Minute Check. Compare scores.
- **Day 30:** Pick the next biggest risk and plan one more step.

Keep it proportionate

You do not have to do everything. If time is short, do these five and stop:

1. Reset your advertising ID.
2. Set location to "While using" for all apps.
3. Use an alias for new sign-ups.
4. Remove your details from the top three people-search sites.
5. Send one access request, to see what a company really holds.

Conclusion: One Less Owner

Somewhere in the world right now, a profile of you is being updated. It may be accurate or not, valuable or not. Almost certainly, it exists.

This book was not written to frighten you out of the digital world. It was written so that you can walk back into it with open eyes. The receipt with forty names is real, but it is not fixed. Each time you decline an optional permission, use an alias, reject a tracker, file a request or close an old account, a name comes off the list.

Three ideas are worth keeping.

Sharing is a decision, even when it is made quickly. Learn to notice the moments when a decision is being made for you, and make it yourself.

Small, steady steps beat grand gestures. The five habits at the end of Chapter 13 will do more than a month of anxiety.

You are one of the owners. Your data has more than one owner, and you are the only one who started out with all of it. You still have rights, tools and choices.

Choose fewer owners. Choose them on purpose.

APPENDIX A

Data-Sharing Map

Build this as a spreadsheet for your business, or for your household's most-used services. One row per tool or service. Add rows as you find them.

Tool or service	What it receives	Why	Recipient role	Stored where	Contract or policy checked?	Action
Website analytics						
Advertising pixel						
Email platform						
Payment provider						
Courier or delivery						
CRM or helpdesk						
Chat widget						
Cloud storage						
AI assistant						
Accountant or bookkeeper						
Social media						
Other						

Recipient role codes: Processor, Controller, Joint controller, Unknown.

Action codes: Keep, Reduce, Remove, Get contract, Update notice, Ask vendor.

APPENDIX B

Rights Request Letters

Copy, fill in the blanks and send to the organisation's privacy contact. Keep a dated copy and diarise one month. Adapt for your country's law.

1. Access request (GDPR Article 15)

Subject: Subject access request

Dear Data Protection Officer / Privacy Team,

Under Article 15 of the GDPR, I request a copy of all personal data you hold about me, and the following information: the purposes of the processing; the categories of data; the recipients or categories of recipients to whom it has been or will be disclosed, including those in third countries; the retention period; the source of the data if not collected from me; and the existence of any automated decision-making or profiling.

My details so you can identify me: Name _____ Email _____ Account or customer number _____

Please reply within one month. If you need proof of identity, tell me what you need.

Yours sincerely, _____ Date _____

2. Erasure request (GDPR Article 17)

Subject: Request for erasure of personal data

Dear Data Protection Officer / Privacy Team,

Under Article 17 of the GDPR, I ask you to erase all personal data you hold about me, because _____ (for example: the data is no longer necessary; I withdraw my consent; I object to the processing). Please also tell any recipients to whom you disclosed the data, as required by Article 19, and confirm in writing once deletion is complete.

My details: Name _____ Email _____ Account number _____

Yours sincerely, _____ Date _____

3. Objection to marketing and profiling (GDPR Article 21)

Subject: Objection to direct marketing and profiling

Dear Data Protection Officer / Privacy Team,

Under Article 21 of the GDPR, I object to the processing of my personal data for direct marketing, including profiling related to direct marketing. Please stop all such processing immediately, suppress my details from all marketing lists, and confirm in writing.

My details: Name _____ Email _____ Phone _____

Yours sincerely, _____ Date _____

4. Opt-out of sale or sharing (US state laws)

Subject: Request to opt out of sale and sharing of personal information

To the Privacy Team,

Under the privacy law of my state of residence, I request that you stop selling or sharing my personal information, including for cross-context behavioural advertising, and that you treat this as a request to limit the use of any sensitive personal information. Please confirm in writing.

My details: Name _____ Email _____ State of residence _____

Sincerely, _____ Date _____

APPENDIX C

The Settings Checklist

Work through this once, then every six months.

Phone

- ☐ Advertising ID reset; personalised ads off
- ☐ Location set to While using or Never for each app
- ☐ Precise location off where not needed
- ☐ Camera, microphone, contacts, photos and calendar access reviewed
- ☐ Apps you do not use deleted
- ☐ Privacy report or dashboard checked
- ☐ Lock screen previews hidden for messages

Browser

- ☐ Strict tracking protection on
- ☐ Third-party cookies blocked
- ☐ Global Privacy Control enabled
- ☐ Extensions reviewed; only trusted ones kept
- ☐ Autofill and saved payment cards reviewed
- ☐ Separate profile used for shopping or social media

Email and accounts

- ☐ Remote images blocked in the mail app
- ☐ Aliases used for shops and newsletters
- ☐ Two-step verification on for email, banking and main accounts
- ☐ Connected apps on main accounts reviewed
- ☐ Ad personalisation off on major platforms
- ☐ Location, search and voice history set to auto-delete

Home devices

- ☐ Smart TV viewing information and interest-based ads off

- ☐ Voice assistant recordings not stored or set to auto-delete
- ☐ Smart devices on a guest network
- ☐ Old devices factory-reset before sale or disposal

Family

- ☐ Children's device and app settings reviewed
- ☐ Photo location metadata stripped before posting
- ☐ School and club consent forms checked for sharing

APPENDIX D

Privacy Policy Reading Guide

Use this to read any policy in five minutes. Copy one per service.

Service: _____ **Date read:** _____

Question	Where to look	What I found	Concern?
What do they collect beyond what I typed?	"Information we collect"		
Do they collect precise location?	"Location"		
Why do they use it?	"How we use"		
Is data used for advertising or profiling?	"Marketing", "Personalisation"		
Who receives it?	"Sharing", "Partners"		
Do they sell or share it?	"Your choices", "California"		
Is data sent abroad?	"International transfers"		
How long is it kept?	"Retention"		
How do I opt out or delete?	"Your rights"		
Who do I contact?	"Contact us"		

Verdict: Keep using / Use with settings changed / Stop using / Ask a question first

Red flags: vague "partners" with no categories; no deletion route; no named contact; policy last updated more than three years ago.

APPENDIX E

Removal Tracker

Record every removal or rights request. Re-check after 30 to 60 days.

Site or company	Date requested	Method	Reference	Reply date	Result	Re-check date

Method codes: Web form, Email, Letter, DROP, Browser signal.

Result codes: Removed, Partial, Refused, No reply, Reappeared.

If there is no reply: wait for the legal period, send one polite reminder quoting the date of your first request, then consider a complaint to your data-protection authority or state regulator.

Glossary

Adequacy decision. A finding by the European Commission that a non-EU country gives essentially equivalent protection to personal data.

Advertising ID. A resettable identifier on a phone that lets apps and advertisers link activity.

Controller. The organisation that decides why and how personal data is processed.

Cookie. A small file a website stores in your browser to remember you.

Data broker. A company that collects personal data from many sources and sells or licenses it.

DPA (data-processing agreement). The contract between a controller and a processor.

DROP. California's Delete Request and Opt-out Platform for data brokers.

Fingerprinting. Recognising a device by its combination of settings and features.

Global Privacy Control (GPC). A browser signal that tells sites you opt out of sale or sharing.

Inference. A guess about a person drawn from data, such as income or interests.

Joint controllers. Two or more organisations that decide the purposes and means together.

Pixel. A tiny image or script that reports when a page or email is viewed.

Processor. An organisation that handles data on a controller's behalf and instructions.

Real-time bidding (RTB). The automated auction for ad space that runs as a page loads.

SCCs (standard contractual clauses). Approved contract terms for transferring personal data out of the EEA.

SDK. A library of third-party code embedded in an app.

Sub-processor. A supplier used by a processor.

Third party. A recipient that uses data for its own purposes.

A Note on GDPRGard.eu

GDPRGard publishes free tools, guides and articles to help small businesses understand data-protection duties in plain English, including how to map data sharing, check cookies and trackers, and respond to rights requests. Visit **gdprgard.eu** for current guidance, templates and updates to the topics in this book.

About the Author

Zirlandia Milkovic writes practical, plain-English guides on data protection, AI and building a business with confidence. She believes privacy is not a barrier to ambition but a foundation of trust, and that nobody should need a technical degree to understand who holds their information.

She is the author of a series of business guides, including *GDPR Made Simple for Women Founders*, and her work focuses on turning complex rules and fast-moving technology into simple steps, checklists and templates that busy people can actually use. She is also behind **GDPRGard**, a growing collection of free GDPR tools, guides and articles for small businesses, available at gdprgard.eu.

Your Data Has More Than One Owner grew out of a simple observation: most people know whom they gave their information to, and almost nobody knows who got it next. If this guide helped you, an honest review where you bought it helps other readers find it.

Visit **gdprgard.eu** for free tools, articles and updates.

Notes and Sources

Research cut-off: 9 November 2026. Items marked (read) were opened directly; others were seen through search summaries or secondary coverage and should be checked against the original before you rely on them.

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3. US Federal Trade Commission, Avast Limited and Jumpshot, $16.5 million settlement announced February 2024 and finalised in June 2024; browsing data sold to more than 100 third parties (secondary coverage read; read the FTC press release and complaint).
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6. Court of Justice of the EU, Case C-40/17, Fashion ID, judgment of 29 July 2019, on joint controllership for social-plug-in embedding (working knowledge).
7. Latanya Sweeney, work on uniqueness of demographic data (early 2000s): the 87% figure for ZIP code, date of birth and sex is widely cited; later analyses report lower figures (working knowledge).
8. Regulation (EU) 2016/679 (GDPR), Articles 7, 15 to 22 and Chapter V (transfers). The UK GDPR contains equivalent provisions; the ICO publishes guidance.
9. European Commission, adequacy decision for the EU-US Data Privacy Framework, 10 July 2023; General Court judgment of 3 September 2025 in Case T-553/23 Latombe v Commission dismissing the challenge; appeal lodged 31 October 2025 as Case C-703/25 P and, per sources read, still pending at the time of searching (secondary coverage read; check the Court's register for the current status).

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12. California Consumer Privacy Act as amended: definitions of "sale" and "sharing"; state laws on opt-out preference signals vary by state (working knowledge).

Not verified by the author: any statistic from an advocacy or vendor report beyond those listed, the exact settings and menu names in specific products, the current status of any appeal or enforcement action, and the exact deadlines under US state laws. The stories of Maya, Daniel, Greenfield Steps and Lark and Loom are fictional.